

2025 AZA CONVERSATION GRANTS FUND

Cover Sheet

Title of Project: Protecting the Endangered Hawksbill Turtles

Student Name: [REDACTED]

Institution: University of Omaha, Nebraska

Project Duration: January 10, 2026 - January 10, 2027

Project Category: Animal/Population Management and Conservation
Education/Engagement

Project Abstract (limit 250 words):

This project focuses on protecting Hawksbill turtles whose populations are decreasing rapidly and are critically endangered. The Hawksbill turtle will inhabit the local Henry Doorly Zoo, where their habitat will be enhanced to better simulate natural conditions and ensure high welfare standards while protecting them from predators such as sharks. An educational movie will be made to inform visitors of all ages about the causes of the species' rapid decline in populations, and the action they can take to support conversation. These efforts aim to support ongoing work and raise public awareness about illegal wildlife trade. The project will collaborate with private and non-profit organizations to accomplish ex situ conservation and highlight the urgent threats facing Hawksbill turtles.

Project Narrative

1. Project Overview and Significance

Hawksbill turtles are greatly affected by habitat loss and illegal trade. Despite their protection under the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES), illegal trade of Hawksbill turtle shells remains widespread. This project aims to combat the illegal trade of Hawksbill turtles by increasing awareness and promoting responsible customer behavior such as donating to Hawai'i Island Hawksbill Turtle Recovery Project and National Save The Sea Turtle Foundation or simply not buying jewelries made from turtle shells. Also, providing high-quality ex-situ care for Hawksbill turtles at the Zoo supports public education and raises awareness about the threats they face in the wild. Currently, only an estimated 8,000 adult nesting females remain worldwide. Hawksbill turtles' population declined by over 80% globally in the last century. The Hawksbill turtles were designated critically endangered by ICN in 1996, and their population has been declining since.

2. Goals, Objectives and Actions

Long-term goals and immediate objectives

The project's long-term goal is to contribute to reducing illegal trade through increased public awareness and engagement. Immediate objectives include encouraging consumers to avoid purchasing illegal turtle-shell products and increasing public understanding of how demand drives exploitation. Also, increasing awareness of climate-related habitat threats, emphasizing how human actions influence nesting and feeding environments.

Actions

In collaboration with both private and non-profit organizations as well as Henry Doorly Zoo, we will incorporate free theater in the zoo to educate adults and children about the issues that Hawksbill turtles are facing, emphasize the importance of donating and boycotting, and lastly the ways they can help them. To further spread awareness, the project will use platforms such as TikTok to share short educational videos about Hawksbill turtles' conversation. The Hawksbill turtles will have their own section at the aquarium to protect them from predators, and they will be constantly monitored and have routine checkups. Their aquarium will be regularly cleaned by hired professionals.

3. Methods

1. Enhance the existing aquarium exhibit to create a separate section that highlights Hawksbill habitat needs and threats, using durable materials and proper signage.
2. Staff will have behavioral assessments and routine health evaluations to ensure welfare and proper acclimation.
3. After their own divided section is made and their environment is well-suited for them by adding some coral reefs, the transportation of the Hawksbill turtles to the aquarium will begin.
4. Once they are settled in their environment, the staff will regularly check up on them by conducting health tests on them, and they will also clean up their environment.
5. From the funds of the organizations, a short movie will be made, and the theater will be free for anyone to come in. The short movie will include actual footages of Hawksbill turtles, the current threats they are facing, illegal trade, the trade of the Hawksbill turtles that is currently happening in Japan and China, why the trade persists, the causes of habitat loss, and the ways they can help by reducing greenhouse gases emissions and other ways they can help.

6. Lastly, a short video will be made to spread on social media highlighting the illegal trade, why the trade persists despite the Hawksbill jewelry being illegal to sell, emphasizes boycotting and the ways they can help.

4. Timeline

One year timeline

January 10th – begin the construction of the new section in the aquarium.

January 20th – begin the production of the short movie

April 15th- Exhibit enhancement completed; coordination begins with partners for ambassador turtle placement.

April 20th – End of the production of the short movie; finish up any renovation

May 25^h – Have the Hawksbill turtles well-adjusted to their new environment

September 13th- start playing the movie at the theater in the zoo

December 10- make a short informational video to spread on social media

5. Evaluation and Outcomes

To determine if the project met its objectives, the project's success will be evaluated through visitor surveys, engagement analytics, and assessments of public awareness before and after outreach activities. We will also observe the search trend of Hawksbill turtles to see if there was virality and increased awareness.

6. Dissemination

The results will be shared through collaboration with zoo partners, educational posters, and social media updates.

7. Ethical and Welfare considerations

As stated, the Hawksbill turtles will have regular check up every week to ensure that they are in good health and not stressed. Their aquarium will be regularly cleaned every week. Their primary food is sea sponges which will be provided in their aquarium. They will also be given shrimp and squid.

Budget

Budget Item	Cost Estimate	Description
Travel (field site or zoo)	\$_5,000_	e.g., fuel, vehicle rental
Supplies/construction	\$_9,000__	field gear, printing, software
Equipment/production	\$_5,000_	binoculars, camera trap, lab kits
Outreach Materials	\$_800_	educational posters, brochures
	Total \$_19,800__	

Budget efficiency and justification

Hawksbill turtles are in Caribbean, Indian, and Indo- Pacific oceans which are approximately 1,000 – 1,500 miles away from Nebraska. Transporting animals that much distance takes about a few hundred to a few thousand dollars. The construction and the supplies used to make a divided section in the aquarium will cost around 7,000 dollars for a custom tank. There will be a divided section inside the aquarium instead of a tank using sturdy glass that blocks any predator such as sharks. There can be other animals inside the section with the turtles. For the production and equipment, the movie will have a short duration and low budget, only having important information. Equipment such as health tests are included so that the turtles can have their regular checkup. The money for the Outreach materials will be used to make the posters that further spread awareness about the illegal trade and habitat loss of Hawksbill turtles. Educational posters will also communicate project outcomes and promote continued conservation awareness.

If partial funds were available, the project would mostly prioritize construction and transportation. Any leftover funds would be used to produce the movie.

References

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